USA TRIATHLON

RACE DIRECTOR RESOURCE GUIDE:

UNIFIED RACE COMMAND

INTRODUCTION:

The Unified Race Command Center (URCC) serves as the centralized hub for event communication between race management and city agency representatives. The tenants of the Unified Race Command structure are rooted in the Incident Command System (ICS), which boils down to getting the right people in the right place to speak the same language.

The larger the event, the more necessary a URCC becomes to be able to gather all key decision-makers physically in one place. The centralization of information makes it easier to track the status of incidents as they develop and enables efficient coordination of race related resources and assets. The size and scale of the URCC can be tailored to mirror the size and scale of the event.

In this section, we'll explore the key components of a Unified Race Command:

- Command and Control
- Unified Race Command Center Operations
- Resources
- Incident Response Tracking
- Situation Reports
- Post-Event Analysis

**Note: While this Guide does provide recommendations for Communications and Emergency Response, all planning and decision-making regarding the event is at the discretion of the local Race Director. Additionally, this Guide does provide direction on the competition rules, but it is not a replacement for the Official Multisport Competition Rules. For questions about the rules and their application at your event, please reach out to rulesandofficials@usatriathlon.org.*

COMMAND AND CONTROL:

The formation of Unified Race Command and Control establishes clear lines of who is in charge of the event during certain conditions and how decisions are to be made. This pre-defined chain of command facilitates more efficient communication and action.

In general, race management has the reins as the operational leader of event activities, unless there is a Public Safety threat or incident that occurs, at which point Command may be turned over to a government entity. It's important to work with your local municipal contacts to make sure everyone is on the same page about which scenarios warrant this type of handoff (ex. Large-scale weather events, criminal threats or activities, fire incidents).

EVENT ENTITIES	
RACE OPERATIONS	**PUBLIC SAFETY**
• Event Operations Staff • Registration Staff • Screening & Security Teams • Transportation Team • Marketing Team • Legal / Finance Team • Communications / Social Media Team • PR Team • Medical Team • Logistics / Warehousing Team	• Law Enforcement (Local, State, Federal) • Medical / Public Health • Fire • Emergency Management • Department of Transportation • Department of Public Works • Parks Department • Department of Environmental Protection

Public Safety agencies structure their operations and communication using the Incident Command System (ICS). It is best practice for Race Management to also operate using ICS to allow for a seamless workflow with collaborating agencies. This necessitates the following:

- **Appointment of an Incident Commander:** The Incident Commander should be someone who is available to receive real-time information and make decisions. Since the Race Director is typically needed out in the field to oversee operations and may also be occupied with ceremonial and/or media responsibilities, generally it's recommended that the Incident Commander post is held by another staff member. The Incident Commander must be intimately familiar with the race operations and entrusted to make decisions on behalf of the event.

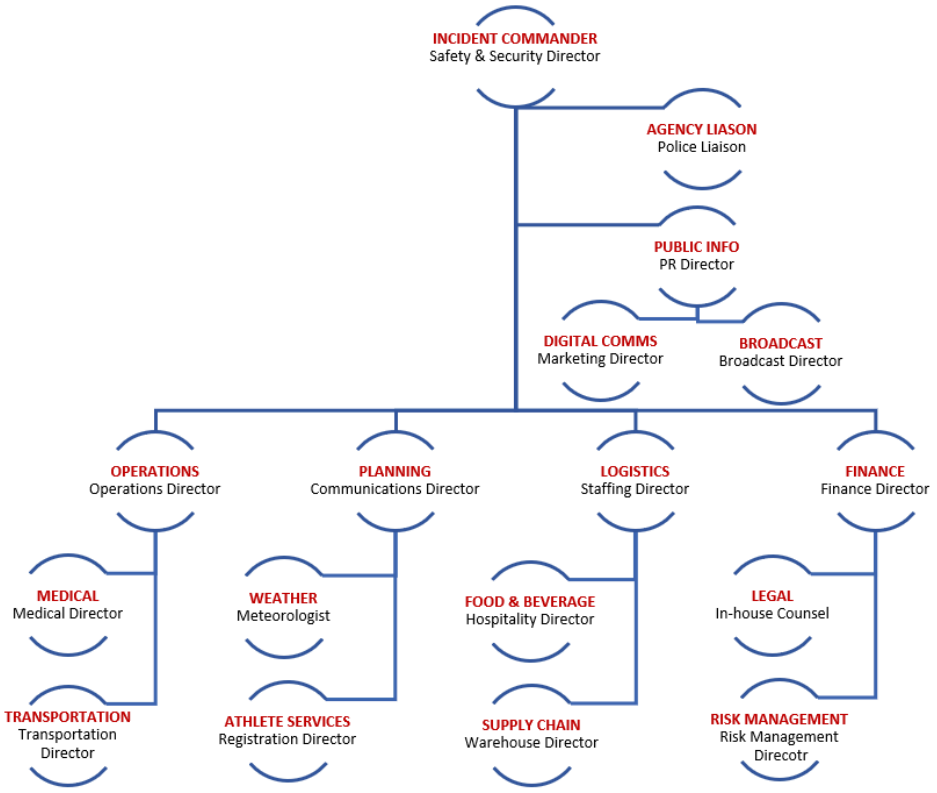
- **Development of a Command Matrix:** The creation of a hierarchy of communication and reporting allows personnel to understand their role in the Command structure. The ICS structure divides personnel into (4) areas: Operations, Planning, Logistics, and Finance/Admin. This is scalable depending on the size of the event. Below is an example of the hierarchical representation of the structure. It is also recommended to provide all agency partners / staff with

a roster of Command representatives along with contact information so everyone is aware of the players involved.

COMMAND MATRIX EXAMPLES

SMALL-SCALE EVENT

LARGE-SCALE EVENT



Personnel Training: Race Management staff working in the URCC should be prepped with their respective roles and assigned duties before, during, and after the event. Key personnel should be provided with the following information to have at the ready on event day:

- **Athlete Data:** The RCC should be provided with access to participant data from the registration platform that includes their personal information, bib # assignment, contact information, and contact information for their emergency contact(s). This data needs to be easily accessible to be able to contact the athlete and his/her emergency contacts if needed.

- **Pertinent Operations Information:** When an incident occurs, time is of the essence to gather the information, loop in the appropriate players, and formulate a response. URCC personnel need to have Race Operations and Contact Information at their fingertips to be able to do the job effectively. Consider putting together a Reference Document that links out to relevant operations documents.

RACE COMMAND CENTER OPERATIONS:

The Unified Race Command Center (URCC) is a designated physical location for decision-makers to gather and operate on-site at the event. The URCC serves as the centralized hub for information flow and resource deployment for race management and city agencies.

For small events, the URCC may be a predetermined, fixed location at the event site that is not permanently staffed but is used as a gathering point for ICS stakeholders in the case of a critical incident. For larger events, the URCC tends to be a robust setup with the space and technological equipment to accommodate a multitude of race management personnel, vendors, and municipal agencies. The size and sophistication of the URCC depends on the scope of your events and the number of different jurisdictions involved.

URCC Location: The URCC should be treated as its own mini event venue. As with any event space, it's all about location, location, location! Emergency Management, Fire Departments, and/or Law Enforcement may also provide mobile command posts or provide space at Emergency Operation Centers. A few key considerations for selecting the right spot for the URCC setup at your event:

CLOSE… BUT NOT TOO CLOSE	PROTECTED FROM THE ELEMENTS	TECHNOLOGICAL CAPABILITIES
The RCC should be in a convenient location where personnel can move between the RCC and the race sites (start / finish) but not too close that it's vulnerable to threats. There should also be security present to prevent access to outsiders.	The RCC must be able to fully operate in the midst of severe weather. Indoor spaces will be more risk-resilient than temporary tented structures	The RCC will need access to power and internet. Fixed, hard lines are preferable, but portable solutions can be utilized if necessary (generators / MiFis). Consult with your radio vendor about a location for a base station antenna outside of RCC

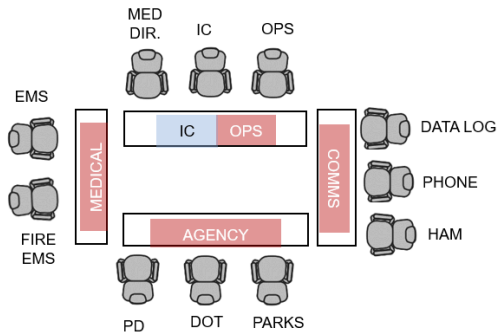
Pro Tip:

Depending on the event size and staff plan, consider the URCC proximity to the Main Medical Tent. At times, it may be helpful for key personnel to be able to check-in with the medical staff in-person.

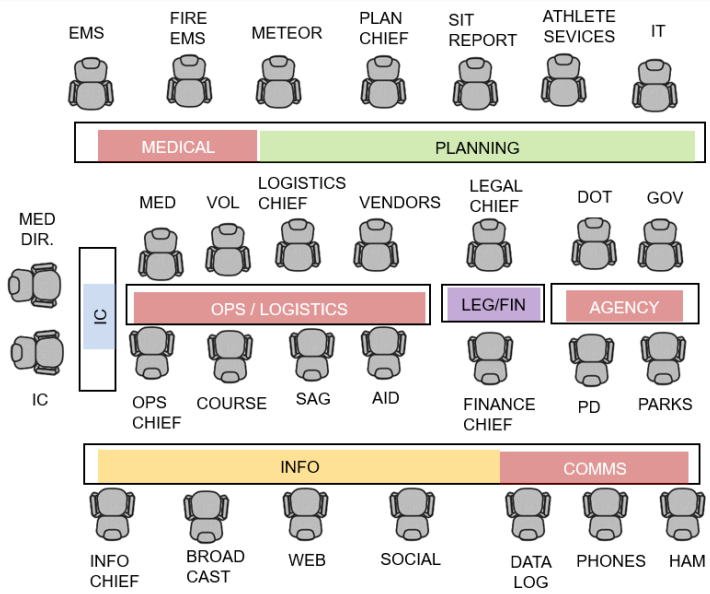
URCC Layout: Once the location of URCC has been confirmed, map out how the space should be configured. As a general rule of thumb, divide the command center by ICS functional area to allow for the effective flow of information.

RCC LAYOUT

SMALL EVENT



LARGE EVENT



Pro Tip:

In large URCC setups, consider having some separation between the IC / Ops Section Chief and agency personnel. This allows your core event team to be able to troubleshoot solvable issues before escalating them up the chain to other agencies. It may not be necessary for agencies to hear every single issue that's communicated over the radio.

For example, if the Parks Department has a rule against driving in the grass and there's a transmission between staff members about driving on the grass, the URCC may be able to step in and stop the behavior before it's even on the radar of the Parks Department representative sitting in the URCC.

RCC Equipment & Supply: The URCC should be equipped with amenities for personnel to be able to work comfortably for the duration of the event. By creating a functional work environment where the URCC can operate self-sufficiently, this eliminates the need for personnel to leave their posts to seek out supplies and therefore, they can focus all attention on the tasks at hand.

RCC EQUIPMENT & SUPPLIES			
EQUIPMENT	**SUPPLIES**	**BASIC TECHNOLOGY**	**FOOD & BEVERAGE**
Tent w/ sidewalls (if outdoors)	White Board w/ dry erase markers	Extension Cords	Catering for all meals
Lights	Notepads / Post-It notes	Power Strips	Coffee, cups, sweeteners
Power source	Pens / Highlighters	Internet Hard Line / Cradlepoint / MiFis	Cooler w/ iced drinks
Tables	Gaff tape (to secure wires)	Hard Phone Line(s) / VoIP phones	Snacks
Temperature control (A/C, fans, heaters)	General Supply Bin (zip ties, tape, scissors, box cutters, snips)	Radios / Base Station(s) / Accessories	Paper Towels / Napkins
Toilet(s)	Tabletop Name Cards printed with entity name and placed at assigned seats	Monitors (if applicable)	Hand Sanitizer
Trash Bins / Liners		Laptop(s)	

External Coordination Centers: In some scenarios, law enforcement may choose to operate their own separate Joint Operations Center (JOC) at their offices or within a mobile command trailer on-site at the event. This affords the opportunity to utilize their own equipment and resources. In these situations, the race operations team should have a representative in any external coordination centers to ensure seamless communication between these satellite Operations Center(s) and the Race Command Center.

Backup Location: During an emergency situation, redundancy is critical in maintaining operational control. Designate a backup facility to serve as the URCC in the event the current location is no longer able to function as a result of a major incident. Consult with your municipal and law enforcement contacts to see if it might be possible to utilize a city/county facility that may already be staffed and resourced.

RESOURCES:

The function of the Race Command Center is to be able to receive, compile, and organize information to educate decision-making and response. The more information is able to be collected from a variety of different sources, the clearer the picture of the incident becomes. The URCC should look to tap into

Pro Tip:
For each information stream, assign personnel within the URCC to receive the inputs. The information is only valuable if there are resources in place to be able to collect and categorize the intel in a meaningful way. Information without an organized collection system will result in lost details and incidents that go unresponded to. Without the proper planning, too much information can be as debilitating as not enough information.

Consider utilizing the following information streams to gather intel on the happenings related to your event:

- **Race Communications:** The URCC should be monitoring the event communication on all established platforms, including but not limited to commercial radio communications (on all channels), HAM Radio communications, and phone lines. For more information about utilizing event communication technology check out the **Communications Guide**.

- **Geographical Information Systems:** The use of GPS tracking can provide real-time data on the location of assets along the course. The most common question on event day from both race staff and from municipal agencies is the location of the first and last athletes. With the help of technology, this question becomes easier to answer:

TRACK COURSE ASSETS	TRACK LEAD / TAIL PACKAGE	TRACK ATHLETES
Provide GPS tracking devices to course support assets and/or ask permission of course staff to share their cell phone location with the RCC for the hours of the event. If an incident occurs, the RCC will know the closest asset to dispatch for response.	Provide GPS tracking devices to the staff or volunteer lead/tail package along the course to have a real-time location on the first and last athlete. Make this information available to the course and finish teams.	Work with your event timer to get access to the timing data to have real-time intel on when athletes are crossing the timing mats and how many athletes still remain on the course.

- **Weather Monitoring Technology**: The URCC should have access to weather monitoring technology, including wet bulb globe thermometers and wind meters. For larger races, a meteorologist may be part of the URCC roster of personnel on-site at the event and it's likely they will bring these instruments with them to set up on-site. For smaller events, consider purchasing this technology to use in conjunction with weather apps and websites to help guide decision-making. Check out the **Weather Action Planning Guide** for more information on how to prepare for weather related incidents at your event.

- **Social Media Platforms**: Social media has become a valuable asset for event operations as it allows the URCC to monitor attendee feedback about their interactions with the event. It allows the race to see in real time the event elements that are garnering positive sentiment and those that may need improvement. Gone are the days where races have to wait for the post-event survey to understand how attendees experience the event. The immediacy of the feedback provides the URCC with an opportunity to respond and make adjustments as incidents are unfolding. The URCC should be equipped with the ability to monitor posts, hashtags, and trending topics related to the event.

- **Local Media:** The URCC should have access to local media outlets via television or the web to keep a pulse on any local developing stories that may not be related to the race, but could have implications for the event (i.e. traffic accidents, protest groups, etc). In some cases, local media outlets are on-site at the event covering the race and broadcasting live from the venue. The ability to view this broadcast in the URCC provides real-time footage of the event venue to see the flow, functionality, and the look and feel. It also informs the URCC on how the event is being portrayed to the general public which may become important if any negative backlash is expected as a result of the broadcast.

- **CCTV Surveillance Systems:** CCTV (closed-circuit television) is a TV system in which signals are not publicly distributed but are monitored and used for surveillance and security purposes. There are public CCTV cameras installed by law enforcement and the Department of Transportation along many roadways. Engage with your local municipal contacts about whether there are any camera locations along the route and/or at your site venue. Access to CCTV feeds can provide visual insights on route and venue conditions, athlete flow, and security enforcement. For large scale events, it's common to have private cameras installed to be used in conjunction with public cameras to allow for greater surveillance coverage at key locations. Cameras vary in terms of sophistication, but events are beginning to use softwares that incorporate automatic detection capabilities including facial recognition, drone detection, and gunshot detection.

DID YOU KNOW?

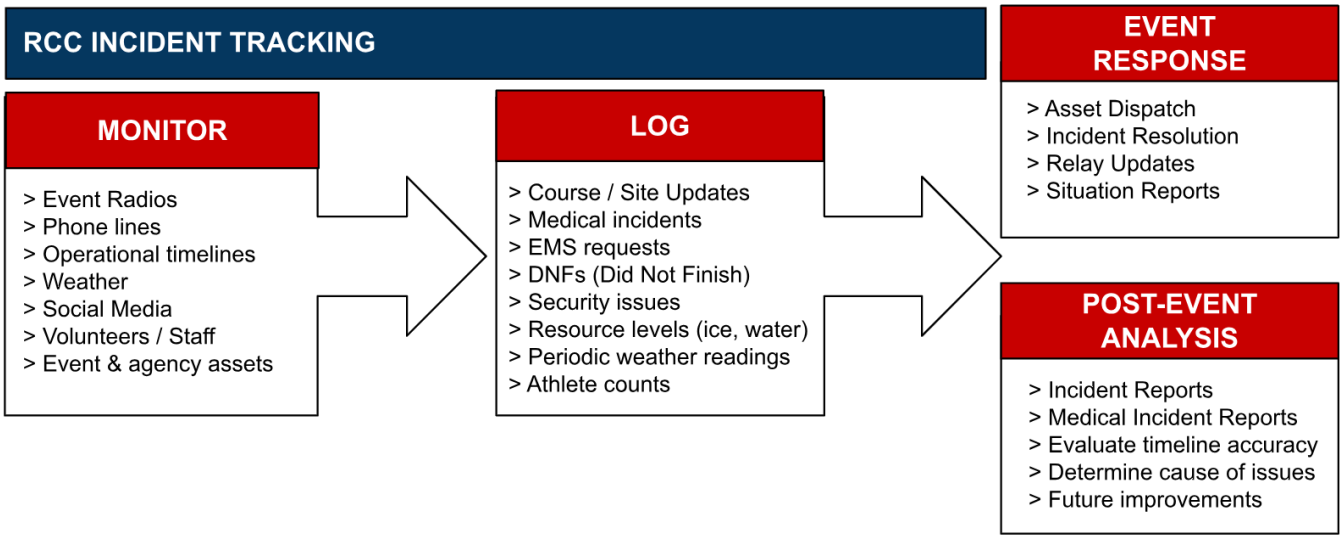
Work with private and public CCTV providers to develop a retention policy for footage. In situations where incidents arise and there is potential for litigation, access to the footage in the months following the event may be beneficial.

INCIDENT RESPONSE TRACKING:

As the Unified Race Command Center receives all informational inputs, the next step is logging the data in a usable, systematic format. The creation of a centralized data logging system benefits the race during and after the event:

- **During the event:** Tracking the status of incidents provides all URCC stakeholders with an at-a-glance view of the situations that need to be addressed, what action has been taken so far, and if there is any follow up required. With the fast-paced nature of events, it's easy for incidents to get lost in the shuffle and back-burnered as new situations arise. An incident tracking system helps to ensure situations remain top-of-mind until they are resolved.

- **Post-event:** Cataloging all occurrences in one centralized place during the race, creates an official record of event happenings which can be referenced post-event. The log of incident details, timestamps, and response times becomes a helpful resource for after-action reports, litigation situations, and debrief meetings. This data can come to drive future decision-making to improve event operations and safety procedures.



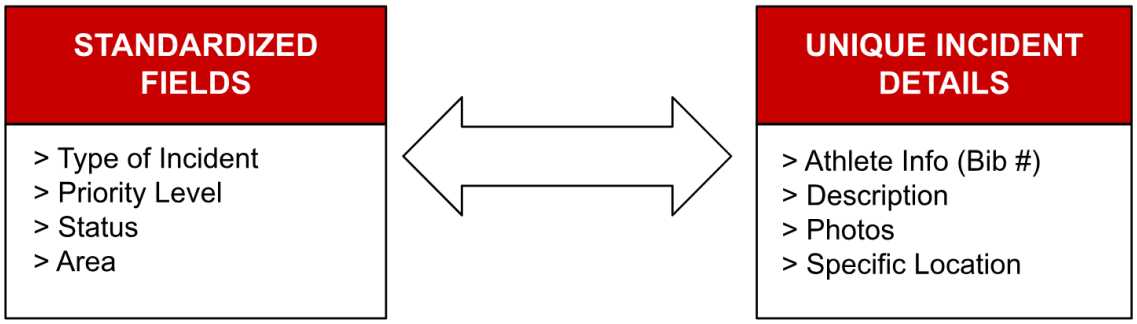
Types of Incident Response Tracking: Prior to the race, establish a system for incident response tracking that will be used in the URCC during the event. This can be as simple as creating a shared spreadsheet that can be referenced by URCC members. For larger-scale events with more budgetary resources, there are also paid software programs that offer more high-tech means of incident tracking. Regardless of the size, scale, or sophistication of the program, it should meet the following criteria:

- **Centralized Digital Repository**: There should be one centralized tracker (as opposed to multiple documents) so all information lives in one place.

- **Web-Based:** The tracker should be shareable so that updates are able to be viewed in real time from any location.

- **Mobile Device Accessibility:** The tracker should be viewable on a mobile phone so that that entities not stationary in the URCC are also able to view (i.e. Race Director)

The Incident tracker requires a balance of standardized inputs and unique incident details to maximize efficiency in response:

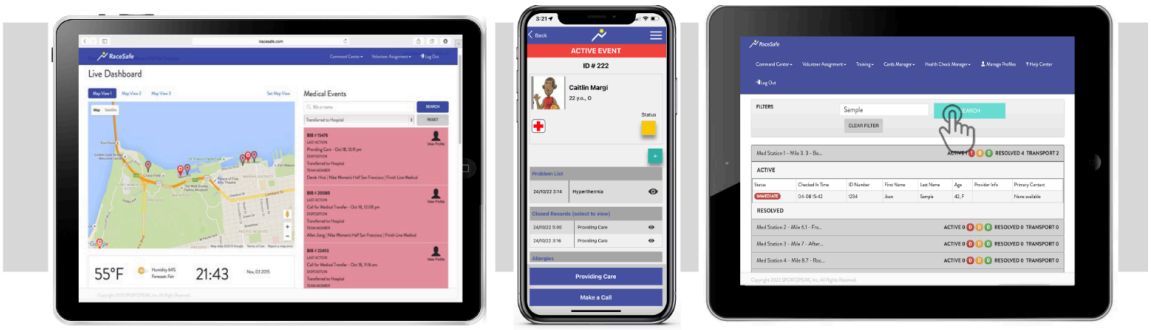
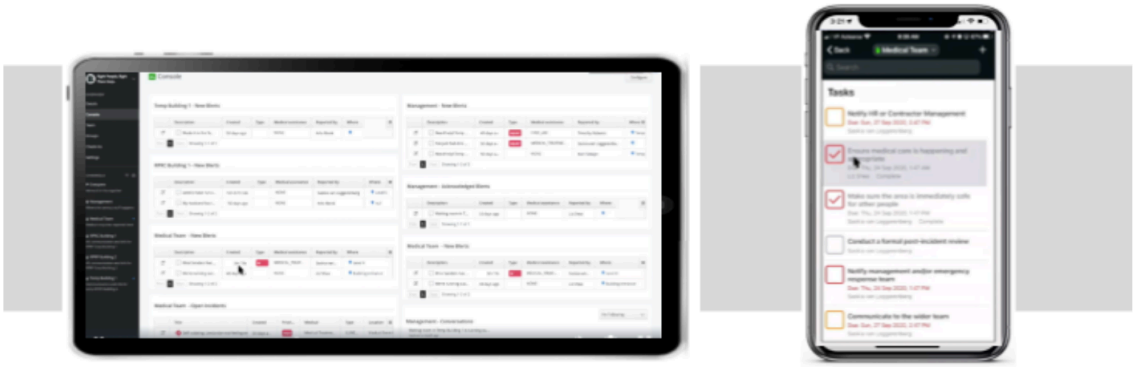


Standardized fields create consistency in how incidents are reported. This allows the tracker to be filtered/searched to identify items that may still require attention from certain groups.

The more details are able to be logged about an incident, the better! This helps ensure the correct response is issued on-site and can provide helpful insight post-event to correct issues from happening in the future.

There are many Incident Response Tracking softwares on the market that may be able to meet your needs. Below are a few Incident Response Tracking solutions to consider for your event based on the size, scale, and the number of races held annually.

INCIDENT RESPONSE TRACKING SOLUTIONS	
PROGRAM	**DETAILS**
Create Your Own Shared Template	**Template:** Command Log Template (available resource on Triathlon Learning) **Cost:** Free **Key Features:** ● Race management to create a web-based shareable spreadsheet ● Ability to customize fields to the race needs ● Easy-to-use with little training required
RaceSafe	**Company:** RaceSafe **Website**: iracesafe.com **Cost:** Paid Subscription- Setup fee + cost per athlete **Contact:** Anthony Luke, anthony@iracesafe.com **Key Features:** ● Specifically created for event medical teams ● Participants have the ability to enter their medical information in HIPAA-Secure platform which can be viewed by the medical team if the athlete is a patient on-site ● Mobile app feature for Medical personnel to enter incident details and update patient status on their phones ● Web-based Command dashboard that includes status and GPS tracking of all incidents

	• Medical volunteer recruitment, assignments, training, communication platform • Data outputs and reporting capabilities  *GPS Tracking of EMS resources and medical incidents* *Mobile App for Medical Team Reporting* *Medical Incident Tracking Dashboard*
Blerter	**Company:** Blerter **Website:** blerter.com **Cost:** Paid **Contact:** Chris Randle, chrisr@blerter.com **Key Features:** • Ability to create staff teams based on areas/responsibilities and filter communication and updates by area • Recommended for the tracking of DNFs, timing issues, and critical incidents. Ability to upload photos and additional details to save on record for each incident. • GPS tracking of all incidents reported • Post-event, detailed incident report data can be generated to show volume of incidents, types, locations, and response times.  *Incident Tracking Dashboard* *Mobile view of assigned tasks*
SEEM (Special Event Emergency Management)	**Company:** Krizik Consulting Strategies **Website**: krizikconsulting.com **Contact:** Scott Hutmacher, shutmacher@krizikconsulting.com **Cost:** Paid- Custom packages built per event need **Key Features:** • Krizik Consulting Strategies is a full-service consulting emergency management firm that can assist with all aspects of Command management from EAP (Emergency Action Plan) creation, municipality coordination, Command setup, and on-site management. • SEEM Incident Dashboard aggregates data from all sources into one digestible

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- Tracking and mapping of medical and operational incidents
- Customizable Mobile Dashboard with versions for Staff and Volunteers to view general event info / updates / athlete counts and version for Medical Team to view status of medical incidents
- Post-event reporting and aggregation of all data to provide actionable insights for future planning

Command Incident Dashboard *Staff / Volunteer Version* *Medical Version*

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<td>IMS (Incident Management System)</td>
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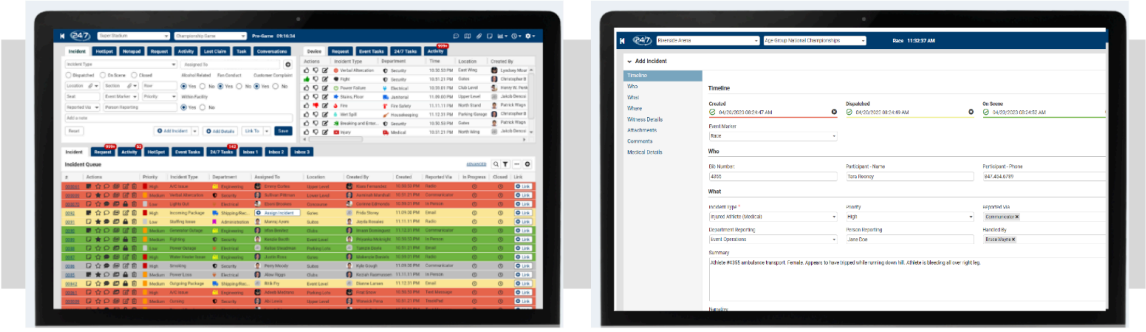
Company: 24/7 Software
Website: 247software.com
Cost: Monthly or Annual subscription
Contact: Tara Rooney, trooney@247software.com
Key Features:

- Color coded dispatch queue for all incidents logged with segmentation capabilities to allow only certain groups to see certain information
- Create staff teams based on areas/responsibilities. Filter communication and updates by area
- Task list feature which can log to-do lists for each area
- Ability to customize requested information fields based on information type. Incidents are able to be updated in real-time with status changes, additional details, and supporting photos
- Data outputs and reporting capabilities



Command Incident Tracking Dashboard *Incident information fields are customizable by incident type*

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SITUATION REPORTS:

During the race, there will be event stakeholders who are not located in Command but will want to stay abreast of the overall status of the event (i.e. Race Director, municipal contacts, key event staff). Consider having the Race Command Center send Situation Reports, which include general event information and updates in an easy-to-read format.

Situation Reports should be sent on a consistent, pre-set schedule every 30 minutes using a template that has been created prior to the event. Here are a few key fields to include in your report.

- Time of Day
- Event Alert System (EAS) Level
- Weather Conditions
- Expected Event Timeline vs. Actual Event Timeline
- Lead / SAG locations
- High-Level Operational Updates
- High-Level Medical Updates (i.e. # of transports)

POST-EVENT ANALYSIS:

Building out a functional Unified Race Command Center may involve additional financial and staffing resources, but it can play an integral role in life-saving response if a critical incident occurs. The URCC is an investment in the safety and well-being of participants and can also be seen as a way to improve the race for future years. By taking the time to catalog all the happenings of the day, this provides the ability to review all incidents post-event to determine how these can be prevented and/or better managed in future years.

To take this data aggregation one step further, compare the URCC data year-over-year to see trends that occur at your events. Once you have a better understanding of how participants engage and interact with the race, you can make educated, data-driven decisions when it comes to the event operations. These adjustments can have cost-saving implications that positively affect the bottom line. Here are some examples:

- **Athlete Numbers:** Record the number of athletes that start the race and compare against the number registered for the event to determine the attrition numbers (dropoff rate). These numbers can inform more accurate order quantities for athlete items such as swim caps, medals, and t-shirts and also race-day consumables such as cups, hydration, and athlete food.

- **Event Timeline:** Cataloging an accurate setup, event, and breakdown timelines for certain locations along the course can help identify the true time windows that road closures, police details, and staff members are needed in positions along the route. By fine-tuning these timelines, you may be able to reduce unnecessary on-site time for these assets which can reduce costs.

Case Study:

Prior to the 2023 Life Time Miami Marathon and Half Marathon, Krizik Consulting Strategies conducted an analysis of the past 3 years of Race Command Center logs. After aggregating all the data, they noticed that a particular 1-mile stretch of the course saw significantly more medical transports than any other portion of the route. The data revealed that the mass of athletes were hitting this section right at a time of day where the Miami humidity levels were consistently rising. This timing coupled with the terrain and limited shade cover contributed to the above average medical incident rates.

To proactively address these trends for the 2023 event, the team worked with the local EMS and private medical providers to increase the number of units along this stretch of the course. They briefed staff members working this zone of the historical trends, with the heads up to be on the lookout for athletes who may be in need of assistance. During the event there was a cardiac arrest incident that took place within this exact stretch of the course and because of the increased medical presence, they were able to respond to the incident in less than a minute. This quick response time contributed to a successful outcome where the athlete was quickly transported to a nearby hospital and ultimately saved.

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